Anti-Recipes — Rock

Sounds like: what makes rock mixes sound amateur

ACCURACY A

Stock Reason nails this sound.

TESTED - settings verified in a session

Starting material: any rock session

DO THIS, STEP BY STEP

1. Don't scoop guitar mids. The bedroom-metal V (bass up, mids gone, treble up) sounds huge solo and vanishes in the mix — mids are where guitars live against vocals and cymbals. Cut 400 Hz mud, keep 1–3 kHz.

2. Don't reverb everything. One shared RV7000 send on drums-plus-vocal puts the band in one room. Six different reverbs puts them in six rooms. Amateur mixes drown; pro rock mixes are drier than you think.

3. Don't double the same take by copying and nudging. A copied-and-delayed track is a chorus effect, not a double. Real doubles (played twice) create width from micro-variation. No shortcut sounds the same.

4. Don't compress the room out of drums. Slamming every drum channel kills the room sound that makes drums feel live. Compress the bus, gently, and leave elements breathing.

5. Don't mix guitars louder than the vocal for more energy. Energy comes from arrangement (what drops out before the chorus) and drum performance, not from guitar volume. If the chorus doesn't lift with guitars at reasonable level, the arrangement is the problem.

Why this works

Every one of these errors comes from judging tracks solo instead of in the mix.

The skill you just learned

Solo is a diagnostic tool, not a mixing position.